the concession to be made, but of the consequences to the perception of British power. So, for example, while in practical terms the 1907 convention actually gave little to Russia that it did not already possess, for Curzon the agreement in effect admitted that St Petersburg was just as entitled to influence within Persia as London was.[97]

Together with the practical experience and formative opinion that his travels provided, the other important benefit Curzon derived from these years was the creation of a reputation as an expert on this region of the world. Indeed, Curzon always appeared anxious throughout his career to prove himself more than a mere politician. In 1896, when his work Pamirs and the Source of the Oxus won him a gold medal from the Royal Geographical Society, Curzon confessed the honour gave him greater pleasure 'than it did to become a Minister of the Crown'.[98] For the rest of his years Curzon would continually refer to this period of travel and the works produced as evidence of the superiority of his knowledge over those in the British government who were less experienced.

In 1889, Curzon completed Persia and the Persian Question following a three month journey on horseback through that country. Ultimately, Curzon intended his study to fill a gap he perceived in the British understanding of Persia, and 'to provide an enduring intellectual legacy', reading 'virtually every work published on Persia in a European language' as preparation for his trip.[99] However, although Persia received critical acclaim upon its publication,[100] to a modern eye there is an inherent conflict between Curzon's desire to be considered an impartial Persian scholar, and the political bias he brings to his work. Both Russia in Central Asia and Persia are predicated on analysis of the strategic importance of this area of the world to Britain's interests in India. In Russia and Central Asia, for example, Curzon revealed his early thoughts on Afghanistan, when he noted how it 'has long been the Achilles' heel of Great Britain in the East. Impregnable elsewhere, she has shown herself uniformly vulnerable here'.[101] In the opening pages of Persia Curzon gives his opinion on the ultimate worth of Afghanistan, Persia, Turkestan and Transcaspia: 'To me, I confess, they are the pieces on a chessboard upon which is being played out a game for the dominion of the world.'[102] At heart, Curzon was a strategist, and not an academic.